

# Love thy neighbour(hood)

We love looking at things on a large scale. All of us, without exception. Right now, there are millions of us in India watching the FIFA “World” Cup, and cheering for our favourite teams – plural, because India never makes it to that grand stage.

We revel in the grandest of scales, and have built monuments to proclaim our love for this – from the Taj Mahal to the Pyramids and even the modern, yet mad, constructions of the tallest concrete towers across the globe – the bigger and more grandiose, the better.

Why look only at physical examples? Look at software, apps and services. Microsoft was once the world beater of tech, then it was Apple, Google, Facebook...and the tussle continues. So we all sit back and spend the few hours a week of free time we get, day dreaming about inventing the next Facebook. And a dream that shall remain.

Our cover story this month deals with the subject of Big Data, who collects it and should it bother you that you’re the latest currency on the planet? Companies are trying to attract you towards them like flies to those UV insect light traps...they don’t want you dead, but they certainly want you to be mesmerised!

Nothing wrong with wanting that, unless you don’t buy into the modern capitalist way of thinking. Chances are, you’re looking for a way to hop on the money train and grab a stash for yourself too. So long as we get paid (or better yet, bought by Facebook), absolutely no one cares if humanity is reduced to a bunch of button-pushing, brainless, Yo app users.

Now morality and the future of the human race be damned, lest I be called a preacher, or worse, *\*gasp\** an evangelist! The question on all of our minds is, “How do I get my piece of the pie?” Right?

For starters, stop wanting the whole pie. Stop thinking of beating the people who have already beaten the world. In fact, stop thinking globally to begin with. None of these world-dominating behemoths and leviathans were made or even thought up as those. Facebook was a way for one particular college’s students to interact. It wasn’t built for the world, but the world wanted it, eventually,

after a small group of people decided they couldn’t live without it.

The magic lies in identifying a group with a specific set of needs that aren’t being fulfilled – either at all, or not in a satisfactory manner. How do you do this? Ask yourself: “What do I miss?” Next, you use tools such as Facebook to find out how many more people in your immediate vicinity have the same unscratched itch as you. Start local and do it better than any other service or offering has ever dreamed of. The advantage you’ll have starting out is being able to see people as people, and not just a number in a game of averages. Never take that for granted.

I recently posted on Facebook about a bad experience I had with Box8, a food delivery startup in Mumbai trying to do things a little differently, and I had a couple of people from there call me back and show genuine interest in trying to take my criticism.

This is markedly different from when I had a problem with, say, Amazon.in, where every email was replied to by a different executive, who obviously was not completely familiar with my complaint.

This is where localisation trumps. We Indians aren’t only interested in the cheapest deals anymore, we’re looking at service quality as well. Look at services such as Zomato – although they claim that they’re catering to 12 countries, all I care about is my little corner of a suburb in Mumbai. “Near me” is all that matters in the real world, and not just for food...think plumbers, electricians, deals, discounts, doctors...there’s a whole world of Big Data just begging to be stripped down into useful little local chunks. The only question is, will you be the one to do it? 



**Robert Sovereign-Smith**  
Executive Editor

[robert@digit.in](mailto:robert@digit.in)

**“Morality and the future of the human race be damned, lest I be called a preacher, or worse, *\*gasp\** an evangelist! The question on all of our minds is, ‘How do I get my piece of the pie?’ Right?”**

Liked or hated this column?  
Write in to [robert@digit.in](mailto:robert@digit.in)  
and let me know your thoughts.